DEVELOPMENT MISSION SHAKTI

The Odia Model for Women's Self-Help

The Odisha government's Mission Shakti scheme is quietly transforming millions of women's lives in the hinterlands by helping them surpass gender barriers and making them financially independent

By* ROMITA DATTA *in Bhubaneswar and Jagatsinghpur



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

The ill-lit, tunnel-like room is littered with coir and ropes. A humming machine drowns all other sounds. Then, as the eye adjusts itself to the gloom, the 12 women—some making ropes, some fashioning other objects—become clearer. Before one's eyes, their nimble fingers shape intricate handicrafts. Forty-five year old Kavita Sahoo, who started this enterprise with a handful of members in 2006, is now a successful entrepreneur. Sahoo, whose life was once steeped in poverty, now earns Rs 40,000 a month after all expenses including fair salaries to her staff. She is a beneficiary of the Odisha government's Mission Shakti scheme, a women's empowerment initiative that, in over two decades, has transformed the lives of lakhs of women by giving them independent incomes. At a